

American War of Independence

It attacked the allegiance to the Crown and called for complete independence. More than 100,000 copies of the pamphlet were sold quickly. George Washington remarked, "*Common Sense* is working a powerful change in the minds of men." On June 7, 1776 Richard Henry Lee of Virginia moved a resolution for independence. After much debate the Declaration of Independence, drafted by Thomas Jefferson, was adopted by the Congress on July 4, 1776. This day is celebrated by the Americans as Independence Day.

War

On 2 July 1776, the British under General. Howe attempted to regain what they had lost. Washington was forced to evacuate Long Island. The main American army managed to reach Pennsylvania. While Howe waited in New York for the winter to pass, Washington made a daring attack on Christmas night at Trenton. The British forces were defeated in Princeton.

French Alliance

In 1777 the British attempts at splitting the colonies into two by a campaign from the north failed. However, they managed to occupy Philadelphia. Washington's efforts to take a town near Philadelphia were spoiled by Lord Cornwallis. But the British were defeated at Saratoga. This defeat paved the way for an alliance between France and the Americans. On 6 February 1778, France and America signed two treaties by which France recognized the United States of America and offered trade concessions. By June 1778 England and France were at war.

Victory at Yorktown

In September Washington attacked Yorktown, with a combined American and French troops. On 19 October 1781 Cornwallis surrendered. In 1783, the Peace of Paris was signed. Great Britain agreed to the independence of the United States. The military band played the tune 'The World Turned Upside Down' as British forces departed from Yorktown in 1781.

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